

COMPARATIVE EPISTEMOLOGY

Knowledge, Knower, and Known

*Comparing Madhyasth Darshan, Advaita Vedanta, modern
Western philosophy, and natural science*

Companion to Knowledge, Knower, and Known (AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.org)

Primary MD and Advaita texts; modern philosophy and science sources cited in the study

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Comparison Begins by Matching Levels

- Who is the knower? — Distinct jeevan, empirical jiva, actionless witness, embodied subject, or organism?
- What is knowledge? — Realised understanding, ordinary cognition, liberating insight, warranted belief, or public model?
- What is the world's status? — Perpetually real, dependently real, contested, or methodologically investigated?
- What produces cognition, and what validates it? — These are not always the same question.
- How is characteristic error detected? — Delusion, superimposition, epistemic luck, bias, or failed prediction?
- What role does conduct play? — Content and evidence, preparation and expression, virtue, or external ethical constraint?

Matching levels prevents the empirical jiva, sakshin, and Brahman from being collapsed into one Advaita “knower.”
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MADHYASTH DARSHAN

MD Integrates Knowledge and Conduct

Knowledge is realised understanding of coexistence, jeevan, and humane conduct. The active knower remains distinct, and understanding becomes answerable to life.



Knowledge

Realised understanding of coexistence, jeevan, and humane conduct—not information or conviction alone.



Knower

Jeevan is the active sentient bearer; the human joint form makes knowing communicable and answerable to result.



Validation

Realisation must cohere with behaviour, work, relationship, evaluation, conveyance, and humane tradition.



Advaita Distinguishes Three Levels

Advaita preserves ordinary cognition at vyavahara while denying that subject–object plurality is ultimately independent. The witness is not a second empirical operator.



Empirical jiva

The embodied person perceives, infers, remembers, deliberates, acts, and bears responsibility through body, senses, and antahkarana.



Sakshin — witness

Actionless consciousness in whose presence changing cognitions are manifest; it does not perform perception or inference alongside the jiva.



Paramartha

Brahman is non-dual consciousness. Knower, means, and known do not remain finally independent terms.



Advaita Has Two Orders of Knowledge



Empirical pramanas

Perception, inference, comparison, postulation, non-apprehension, and testimony generate valid cognition within shared life.



Upanishadic shabda

Reveals Self–Brahman identity unavailable to perception and inference; it removes ignorance rather than producing Brahman as an object.



Error and sublation

Adhyasa superimposes self and not-self. Correction sublates error; empirical plurality is ultimately mithya, not sheer non-being.



Liberation

Shravana, manana, and nididhyasana assimilate liberating knowledge. Conduct prepares and may express freedom, but does not constitute brahma-jnana.

Advaita's pramana means a source of valid cognition; MD often uses “evidence” for lived confirmation. The terms overlap but are not equivalent.



Analytic Epistemology Tests Warrant

Modern Western philosophy has no single metaphysical knower. Its central contribution here is a family of precise tests for warrant, competence, testimony, and error.



Knowledge

Propositional knowledge, know-how, acquaintance, and understanding are distinguished; justified true belief is insufficient when truth depends on luck.



Knower

Depending on theory: organism, embodied subject, socially constituted person, stream of consciousness, or irreducible experienter.



Validation and error

Evidence, reliability, safety, intellectual virtue, testimony, and social conditions address false belief, luck, incompetence, and distortion.



Knowing Is Embodied and Social

These approaches resist the picture of a detached inner spectator. They begin from intentional experience, bodily access, skilled activity, and dependence on others.



Phenomenology

Consciousness is consciousness of something; objects are disclosed through temporal, embodied, and perspectival experience.



Embodied and enactive views

Cognition is skilled activity of brain, body, and environment, not only passive construction of an inner representation.



Social epistemology

Testimony, trust, expertise, institutions, and power shape what people can responsibly know and how error is corrected.



Science Prioritises Public Correction

Science investigates organisms, brains, behaviour, reports, and environments through operational methods. It constrains metaphysics without settling every metaphysical question.



Method

Observation, instruments, modelling, experiment, prediction, replication, and review make claims publicly corrigible.



Operational knower

The organism and its measurable brain, body, behaviour, reports, and environmental coupling—not a separately measured metaphysical self.



Boundary

Brain dependence is well established; the hard problem remains open. Neither gap proves jeevan, and no independent evidence establishes post-death continuity.



Four Accounts of the Knower



Madhyasth Darshan

Distinct, enduring, active jeevan; embodied evidence through the human joint form.



Advaita Vedanta

Empirical jiva cognises; sakshin illumines; separate knower is sublated at paramartha.



Western philosophy

Organism, embodied subject, social person, or consciousness—no settled single account.



Natural science

Operationally the organism across brain, body, behaviour, reports, and environment.

The decisive contrast is enduring plural agency versus empirically operative agency whose separateness is sublated, contested, or operationally bracketed.



MATCHED COMPARISON · VALIDATION

Four Standards of Validation



Madhyasth Darshan

Realisation cohering with conduct, work, evaluation, conveyance, and humane tradition.



Advaita Vedanta

Empirical pramanas in their domains; Upanishadic shabda removes ignorance of identity.



Western philosophy

Justification, reliability, safety, competence, testimony, and social epistemic conditions.



Natural science

Reproducible observation, prediction, experiment, replication, and institutional correction.

No method should be credited with evidence it does not supply: ethical coherence, contemplative certainty, and predictive success are not interchangeable.



Three Safeguards for Comparison

- 1 Do not equate shared words — Advaita pramana generates valid cognition; MD “evidence” often names realised understanding confirmed in life.
- 2 Do not equate ethical roles — humane conduct is content and evidence in MD; in Advaita discipline prepares and action may express knowledge; science does not derive value from description alone.
- 3 Do not substitute evidence across domains — post-death persistence, non-duality, ethical transformation, and neural mechanism each require arguments suited to the claim.

Open questions remain: operational markers of jeevan, non-circular conduct-evidence, witness-to-Brahman inference, and coordination of first- and third-person evidence. · Study §§5–7 · 11 / 12

COMPARATIVE CONCLUSION

The Real Dispute Is Now Clear

The traditions differ over what the knower is, whether plurality remains ultimately real, and which forms of evidence can complete a claim to knowledge.

MD

coherent living

Advaita

non-dual insight

Philosophy

*warrant and
experience*

Science

public correction

Comparison is strongest when matched levels are preserved and no tradition's success is allowed to answer a different tradition's question by substitution. ·

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